AFRICA RESEARCH & IMPACT NETWORK

CONSULTATIVE PLATFORM ON CLIMATE AND HEALTH IN AFRICA (CAPCHA)

CONCEPT NOTE

Background

Climate change is a global crisis with far-reaching implications for public health, and Africa stands out as a region particularly vulnerable to the adverse effects of extreme weather events linked to climate variability. This heightened susceptibility is exacerbated by an already strained healthcare system and the absence of robust early warning systems, factors partly attributed to the region's fragile socio-economic conditions. Besides, many African countries have failed to effectively adapt to climate change impacts due to lack of context-specific data to inform action. While research evidence has been identified to be key in furthering sustainable development in policy documents like the 2030 United Nations Agenda and the 2063 African Union Agenda, data generated from the Global North may fail to effectively foster the much-needed transformative change in Africa. Though the data may help inform researchers, policymakers, and communities on how to address C & H issues, they may not be context-relevant, and thus the need to support and augment the capacity of African researchers to enable them to produce context-specific data for action.

From the policy perspective, African countries appear to have national climate change policy and national adaptation plan documents that merely alludes to C & H in barely a paragraph. Regional adaptation plans for different countries, therefore, have to be co-developed to facilitate policy interventions. Moreover, limited funding and inadequate capacity of C & H actors is also another impediment to the advancement of the climate and health agenda in Africa. The noticeable absence of climate change and health courses or fellowships offered within the various African regions further makes it difficult for interested stakeholders to access such courses and enhance their capacity. This inadequacy acts as an obstacle to the effective design and implementation of research and adaptation programs. Compounding the matter is the fact that climate change and health research are often compartmentalized across various disciplines, resulting in a fragmented landscape of specialized discussions. This compartmentalization hinders efforts to synthesize key findings aimed at identifying trends and gaps in the evidence. Advancing the climate and health agenda in Africa will, therefore, depend on how well the linkages between research, policy, and capacity are strengthened in addition to tackling existing inequalities in research.

Urgent action is imperative if economies are to be decarbonized and more resilient health systems developed. This can be accomplished by providing contextualized evidence to support action, leading in climate advocacy and leadership, guiding sectors that significantly affect health through their actions, and assuming responsibility for climate resilience and the imperative to decarbonize healthcare systems. Transdisciplinary research and action agenda on climate change and health can help inform evidence given the human-environmental system problems being currently experienced by society. Considering the importance of collaboration in advancing the C & H agenda, key role players have to be identified and the process has to be intentional to guarantee that regional adaptation plans can be developed for different countries.

Rationale: Why A C & H Platform

The transformation needed to address the health impacts of climate change in Africa will demand innovative approaches of mobilizing resources, working jointly, and applying knowledge. To efficiently address the diverse C & H challenges as well as the varied needs and interests of actors in the different sectors, research must be effectively interlinked with policymaking, planning, and action. The co-generation of data across disciplines is one approach that can foster such transformations. By providing timely and policy-relevant research, researchers can support evidence-based decision-making and effective implementation of climate and health policies.

This can be achieved by creating platforms such as CAPCHA that brings together researchers, policy-makers, and practitioners from various disciplines and sectors. The platform will facilitate knowledge exchange, sharing of best practices, and collaboration on research and policy development. The platform will also be used to encourage regular communication channels such as meetings, conferences, and webinars to help foster dialogue and information sharing between different stakeholders. This will ensure that C & H stakeholders are up-to-date with the latest research, policy updates, and field experiences. Information on the connection between climate and health will equally be provided on the platform as most people view them separately. This can be done by sharing evidence of how climate change can affect the health sector, and similarly how the health sector can get prepared and minimize the negative effects of climate change.

VISION STATEMENT

Building a transdisciplinary community of practice towards enhanced decision support environment on C & H research and policy in Africa

MISSION STATEMENT

Nurturing transdisciplinary science-policy engagements towards advocating for resilient and low-carbon health systems.

Aims and Objectives

The CAPCHA Platform aims to create a coordinated and strategic approach to understanding, mitigating, and adapting to the health challenges posed by a changing climate. By bringing together climate and health stakeholders from various sectors, the platform will address the unique challenges and opportunities that climate change poses for health across the continent. By leveraging regional expertise and fostering cross-border cooperation, CAPCHA will help ensure that Africa is better prepared to protect the health and well-being of its populations in the face of climate change. Unlike other initiatives, CAPCHA aims to integrate real-time data with on-the-ground needs, ensuring that interventions are timely and contextually relevant. This unique approach will shape more resilient health strategies tailored to specific community climate profiles, aligning these efforts with the priorities of funders and decision- makers.

Specific Objectives

Research and Innovation: the platform will centralize data from various sectors and promote joint research for informed decision-making.

Policy and Advocacy: the platform will provide a space for unified voice to advocate for policies that address the health impacts of climate change. Avenues for influencing national and international climate policies to ensure they incorporate health considerations and support the specific needs of African countries and guarantee that health strategies are aligned with broader climate resilience efforts will be provided.

Capacity Enhancement: the platform will help strengthen the ability of individuals, communities, organizations, and governments to understand, anticipate, and effectively respond to the health impacts of climate change. By equipping individuals and systems with the necessary tools and knowledge, capacity enhancement seeks to protect public health, reduce vulnerabilities, and promote sustainable development in the face of climate change.

Multisectoral Partnerships and Collaboration: the platform will promote collaboration across sectors, including health, environment, agriculture, and water, to develop comprehensive policies that address the interconnected impacts of climate change on health.

Components of CAPCHA

- **Database dashboard:** provides users with access to a centralized collection of data and analytics related to the impacts of climate change on health. The dashboard serves as a valuable tool for researchers, policymakers, health officials and other stakeholders, offering a comprehensive view of data, trends, and insights to inform decision-making and strategy development. The dashboard will also function as a comprehensive resource hub, linking climate and health stakeholders by consolidating data on key players in Africa's climate and health sector, major funders, ongoing initiatives, policy developments, capacity-building efforts, and funding opportunities in this field.
- **Knowledge sharing and engagement:** shares knowledge, best practices, and research findings related to the impacts of climate change on health while fostering transdisciplinary collaboration among experts in climate science, public health and epidemiology, policy, and other relevant fields.
- **Knowledge translation and policy:** to bridge the gap between scientific research and practical application, the platform provides a dynamic and responsive interface between science and policy, ensuring that the latest research informs practical actions and strategies. This process is crucial for enabling evidence-based decision-making that can protect and improve public health in the context of climate change by ensuring that research findings are effectively communicated and utilized to inform health policies, practices, and interventions.

Activities

A. Research and Innovation

Africa is among the regions that is most affected by climate change; experiencing more frequent and severe extreme weather events, such as droughts, floods, and heat waves. These events exacerbate health issues by increasing the incidence of water-borne and vector-borne diseases, malnutrition, and respiratory problems. Many African countries have fragile health systems that struggle to cope with the additional burden of climate-related health impacts. Improved data collection and sharing are thus key for understanding the health impacts of climate change and facilitates the development effective interventions. CAPCHA will strive to centralize data from various sectors as well as promote joint research for informed decision-making.

Focus Areas

1. Food security and nutrition
2. Water, Sanitation, and Hygiene (WASH)
3. Vector-borne, Infectious, Neglected-tropical and Non-communicable diseases
4. Air Quality, Urban heat and Occupational health
5. Climate Adaptation and Mitigation
6. Disaster preparedness and response
7. Sexual, Reproductive, Maternal, Newborn, Child and Adolescent health (SRMNCAH)
8. Mental Health
9. Ethical frameworks in Climate and Health Research

B. Policy and Advocacy

CAPCHA will serve as a unified platform to advocate for policies addressing the health impacts of climate change. It will create avenues to influence national and international climate policies, ensuring they incorporate health considerations and support the specific needs of African countries. The platform will also align health strategies with broader climate resilience efforts. Additionally, CAPCHA will provide opportunities for participation in international climate negotiations, advocating for Africa's health priorities and ensuring that global climate actions account for the continent's unique vulnerabilities.

Focus Areas

1. Global Level
2. Regional Level
3. National Level
4. Local Level

C. Capacity Enhancement

Raising awareness about the health risks of climate change and engaging communities in adaptation and mitigation efforts are vital. CAPCHA will support educational campaigns and community-based initiatives while empowering local populations to take action. Integration of health in climate change courses in school curriculum will also be advocated for to guarantee that those who graduate from universities have the needed capacity to tackle transdisciplinary research in C & H. This will be done through:

- ✓ Summer Schools
- ✓ Bootcamps
- ✓ Webinars
- ✓ Seminars/Workshops
- ✓ Short self-paced courses

CAPCHA Developments:

A. Research and Innovation

CAPCHA has already established a comprehensive repository of climate and health stakeholders in Africa, detailing ongoing initiatives, supporting funders, and the geographical reach of each project. This repository was developed through stakeholder engagement during a Wellcome Trust-funded project, focusing on consulting communities of practice for transdisciplinary research and action in Africa. Currently, the research and innovation component is being enhanced with relevant data to transform it into a one-stop resource hub for climate and health initiatives. A key objective of CAPCHA in this enhancement is to integrate real-time, localized climate and epidemiological data to drive targeted interventions in Africa. This data integration aims to inform donor priorities in climate and health and serve as a valuable tool for researchers, policymakers, health officials, and other stakeholders. By offering a comprehensive view of data, trends, and insights, it seeks to inform decision-making and strategy development; a feature that is still under development.

B. Knowledge translation, Policy and Advocacy

CAPCHA has partnered with the Africa Climate and Health Alliance (ACHA) to enhance knowledge translation within CAPCHA, ensuring the timely dissemination of scientific findings, data, and policy briefs to stakeholders such as governments, NGOs, and community groups. This collaboration aims to bridge the gap between research and actionable policy by co-developing accessible materials aligned with policymakers' needs, focusing on climate health resilience, public health, adaptation, and mitigation strategies through:

1. **Evidence Generation and Advocacy:** ARIN and ACHA will undertake joint research initiatives, leveraging their networks to address data gaps in areas like health risks from climate impacts, adaptation measures, and economic costs of climate-related health outcomes. They will coordinate advocacy campaigns to influence national and international bodies, including the UNFCCC COP, promoting climate-health resilience. Workshops, roundtables, webinars and conferences will be organized to discuss findings, raise awareness, and foster cross-sectoral action.
2. **Leveraging NDC 3.0 and Frameworks:** The partnership will align with the NDC 3.0 framework, supporting national and regional climate-health policies that integrate adaptation, health, and resilience. They will provide technical assistance, training, and policy guidance to ensure climate-health considerations are prioritized. Synergies with frameworks like Agenda 2063 will be explored to embed climate-health resilience within sustainable development strategies. Funding and partnership opportunities through climate finance mechanisms will be actively pursued.

3. **Strategic Partnerships and Engagement:** The collaboration will engage a broad range of stakeholders, including governments, private sector actors, civil society organizations, and research institutions, to foster an enabling environment for climate-health integration. Efforts will focus on expanding partnerships in climate resilience, health, agriculture, and sustainable urbanization, leveraging combined expertise and resources to advance climate and health knowledge translation, evidence generation, and policy advocacy across Africa.

C. Capacity Enhancement

In collaboration with partners, CAPCHA, through ARIN, and Columbia University's Mailman School of Public Health, co-developed the Africa Climate and Health Responder Course, which was implemented in the latter half of 2024. The course engaged over 1,000 stakeholders across the continent. Additionally, CAPCHA, through ARIN, hosted its first virtual climate and health conference, attracting over 500 participants from various regions of Africa. This conference facilitated capacity building through the submission of abstracts and full manuscripts, which will be published in a book volume by Taylor & Francis. ARIN is also supporting early-career researchers by providing mini-grants for initiatives that align with its projects, particularly in the climate and health space.

SWOT Analysis of CAPCHA:

Strengths

1. Unique and Comprehensive Approach:
    - CAPCHA's main strength lies in its inclusive, transdisciplinary model, integrating climate change and health sectors. It is one of the few platforms that combine climate resilience, public health, and adaptation strategies with a strong emphasis on data-driven decision-making and policy advocacy.
    - The partnership with ACHA (Africa Climate and Health Alliance) strengthens CAPCHA's capacity to ensure knowledge translation, delivering data and policy briefs to stakeholders like governments, NGOs, and local communities, which is often a gap in other platforms.
2. Strong Network and Stakeholder Engagement:
    - The platform's foundation on collaboration with a diverse set of stakeholders including policymakers, researchers, private sector actors, NGOs, and community representatives, provides a well-rounded approach that is rare in other initiatives. This extensive network enhances its ability to facilitate cross-sectoral action and build consensus across various actors.

- ARIN's existing relationships with over 200 African researchers and the ACHA's presence as a leading advocate for climate-health resilience in Africa give CAPCHA a strong foundation to mobilize resources, co-develop policy briefs, and produce relevant reports.

3. Research Capacity and Data Access:
    - CAPCHA's involvement in joint research initiatives under ARIN while leveraging its extensive research network, helps fill crucial data gaps related to the health impacts of climate change in Africa. The platform can be positioned as a key player in bridging the information gap between scientific research and practical policy recommendations.
    - The capacity-building and enhancing component of CAPCHA, particularly in empowering local stakeholders with research tools, will lead to more localized and context-specific interventions. This localized expertise will set apart CAPCHA from other global platforms that may lack the depth of African-focused solutions.
4. Alignment with NDC 3.0 and Global Frameworks:
    - CAPCHA's alignment with the NDC 3.0 to be submitted in 2025 and other global and regional frameworks like Agenda 2063, the ATACH framework and the Paris Agreement ensures that the platform is not only focused on addressing immediate climate-health challenges but also on long-term sustainable development goals. This strategic alignment opens doors for funding from international bodies and investors looking to support initiatives that align with global commitments.

Weaknesses

1. Challenges in Data Access and Sharing:
    - One of the key challenges that CAPCHA faces is accessing comprehensive, accurate, and timely data on climate and health across the African continent. Despite the platform's efforts to consolidate data, many African countries lack robust data systems or have fragmented data, which hinders the effectiveness of research and policy development. The lack of consistent, open data remains a significant barrier to its mission, limiting the ability to conduct large-scale studies and provide data-driven solutions.
    - This limited access to high-quality data can also undermine the ability to produce robust, actionable policy briefs and reports. CAPCHA will need to overcome this by strengthening partnerships with national governments, research institutions, and international bodies to improve data access and sharing.

2. Capacity Building and Resource Constraints:
    - The technical team working on CAPCHA needs their skills enhanced to ensure they have the capabilities to manage and implement advanced research, data analysis, and technological solutions effectively. Capacity-building efforts should include enhancing their expertise in data management, AI technologies, climate-health analysis, and other relevant areas to strengthen the platform's operational capacity.
    - While CAPCHA's emphasis on capacity-building is a significant strength, there is also the challenge of ensuring that all stakeholders, especially those in low-resource settings, have the necessary skills and tools to engage effectively. Limited access to technology, training resources, and skilled personnel in some African regions can slow the platform's efforts to scale up.
    - Capacity-building initiatives may also be hampered by financial constraints, particularly in ensuring sustained funding for long-term engagement with stakeholders across multiple regions.
3. Sustainability of Partnerships:
    - The platform's success depends heavily on the sustainability of its partnerships, including those with governments, NGOs, and private sector actors. Maintaining these relationships over time and ensuring ongoing commitment to climate-health goals can be challenging, especially when funding cycles end or political priorities shift.

Opportunities

1. Growing Interest in Climate-Health Linkages:
    - The global push towards climate-health resilience, especially with the increasing visibility of climate-related health impacts, presents a significant opportunity for CAPCHA. As climate change impacts more populations, particularly in Africa, the demand for integrated climate-health solutions will increase. CAPCHA is well-positioned to lead efforts to develop practical, evidence-based solutions.
    - As more countries focus on fulfilling their NDCs commitments, CAPCHA can provide a platform for knowledge-sharing and collaboration to enhance climate-health integration within national policies.

2. Emerging Funding Opportunities:
    - The growing recognition of climate and health challenges, both domestically and globally, opens opportunities for CAPCHA to access funding through climate finance mechanisms, international donors, and multilateral organizations. Funding will support the expansion of research, capacity-building, and the implementation of joint initiatives.
    - The platform can also tap into the increasing availability of funds for climate adaptation, mitigation, and public health resilience programs. By aligning its objectives with the goals of international climate and health funds, CAPCHA can attract resources to further its mission.
    - By aligning with global frameworks like the NDC 3.0, Agenda 2063, and the SDGs, CAPCHA can attract more international partners, further strengthening its capacity for joint initiatives and advocacy campaigns in Climate and Health.

3. Technological Advancements in Data Collection and Analysis:
    - Advances in technology, including AI, big data analytics, remote sensing technologies and satellite-based data collection, offer CAPCHA an opportunity to improve its data access and analysis. Partnering with tech companies or research institutions to incorporate cutting-edge technologies into CAPCHA's operations can enhance its data capabilities and expand its reach. CAPCHA can integrate innovative technologies to overcome data challenges, providing real-time, actionable Climate and Health insights for decision-makers across Africa.
4. Expanding Collaborative Networks:
    - As CAPCHA builds its partnerships with organizations like ACHA, ARIN, and other stakeholders, it can leverage these collaborations to expand its network and influence. New alliances with universities, private sector partners, and regional health organizations can provide the resources and knowledge needed to tackle pressing climate-health challenges.
5. Policy Influence and Global Recognition:
    - By aligning with international policy frameworks and actively participating in global climate negotiations (e.g., UNFCCC COP), CAPCHA can amplify its voice and influence at both regional and international levels.
    - This influence can translate into greater recognition and funding, as well as opportunities to shape global climate-health policies.

6. Capacity Building and Knowledge Sharing:
    - CAPCHA has the potential to serve as a model for other regions by demonstrating how capacity building and knowledge sharing can be effectively integrated into climate-health resilience strategies.
    - The platform's focus on training and empowerment is critical for long-term sustainability and can serve as a key driver for positive change in Africa's climate-health landscape.

Threats

1. Political and Economic Instability:
    - Political and economic instability, inconsistent policy frameworks, and fragmented regulatory environments in various African countries may affect CAPCHA's ability to implement initiatives and maintain long-term partnerships. Shifts in government priorities, political unrest, or financial crises could divert attention and resources away from climate-health integration efforts.
    - There may also be resistance from local governments or stakeholders who are not yet fully aware of the health impacts of climate change, limiting the platform's ability to gain traction and could create hurdles in policy adoption and the consistency of support for CAPCHA's initiatives.
2. Competition from Other Platforms:
    - Other platforms focusing on climate change and health, such as the WHO's ClimaHealth Platform, may pose competition for funding, attention, and partnerships. CAPCHA must set itself apart by focusing on its unique strengths, including its localized approach, capacity-building efforts, and strong emphasis on evidence-based policy advocacy.
3. Limited Stakeholder Engagement and Collaboration:
    - Ensuring effective collaboration across various sectors, especially in low-resource settings, can be challenging. Diverging priorities among stakeholders (e.g., governments, NGOs, private sector) might limit the platform's ability to develop a unified approach to addressing climate-health issues.

Why CAPCHA is a Unique Platform

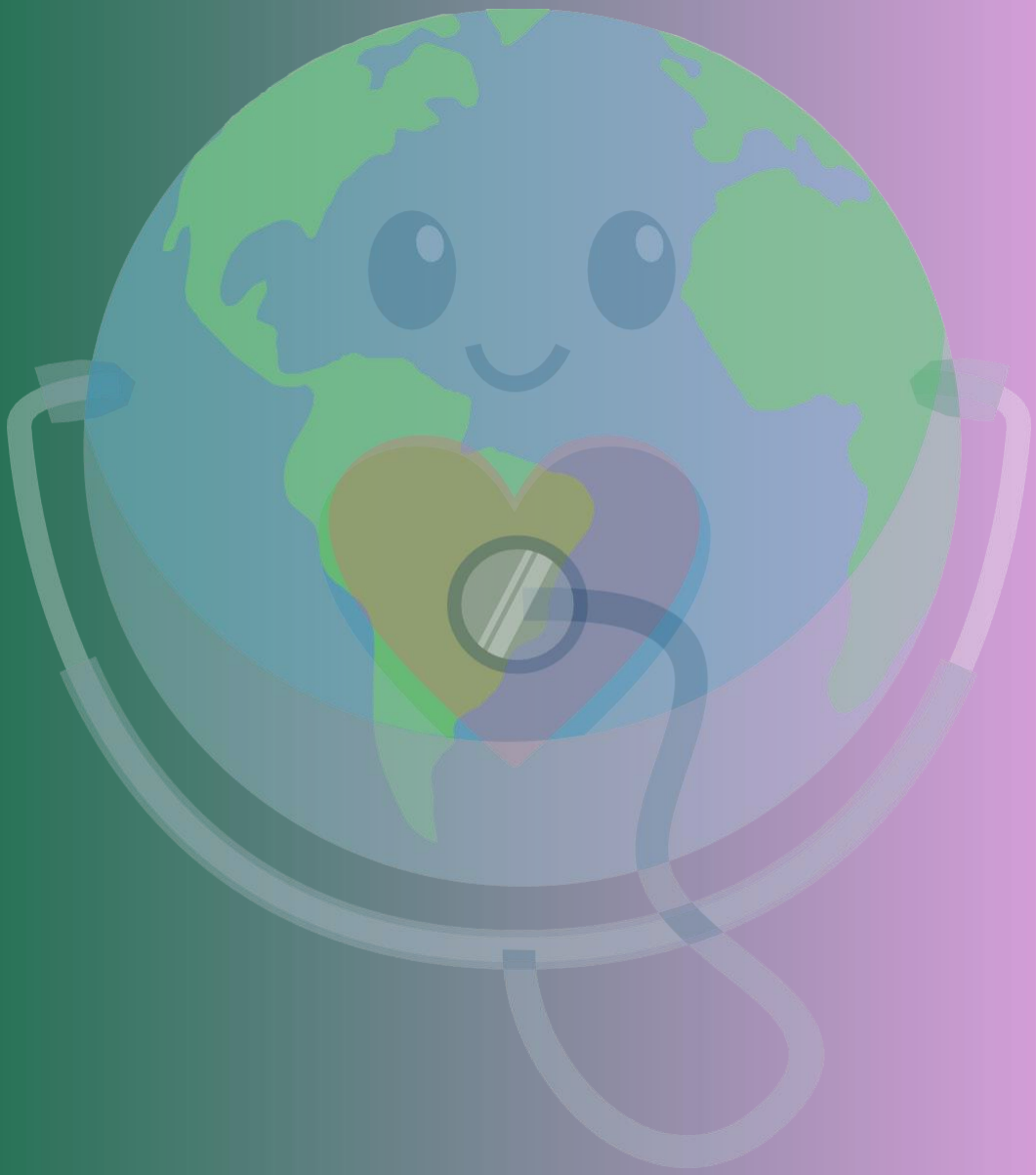
CAPCHA stands out for its ability to integrate climate change and health issues, focusing on actionable, evidence-based solutions tailored to African contexts. Unlike many other platforms that focus on climate or health separately or Climate-health convenings, CAPCHA combines these domains into a unified approach, addressing both adaptation and mitigation strategies while emphasizing public health resilience.

Its partnerships with other stakeholders ensure it has the support needed to create a meaningful impact, particularly through data-sharing, policy development, and capacity building. CAPCHA's emphasis on developing accessible and practical policy briefs, along with its alignment with international frameworks, makes it a platform with both local and global relevance.

Benefits to Partners

- **Governments:** By collaborating with CAPCHA, governments will have access to tailored, data-driven policy recommendations and strategies that address the intersections of climate change and public health. This will help them meet their NDC 3.0 commitments and integrate climate-health resilience into national policies. By collaborating with CAPCHA, governments can also access technical expertise, and training to improve national climate-health resilience.
- **NGOs and Civil Society Organizations:** These partners will benefit from CAPCHA's extensive research and advocacy tools, supporting their work on the ground in improving community resilience and raising awareness about the impacts of climate change on health.
- **Private Sector:** Organizations involved in climate finance, technology, and health innovation will find CAPCHA to be a valuable platform for engaging with stakeholders across sectors, contributing to solutions that align with both environmental sustainability and social responsibility.
- **Research Institutions:** ARIN, academic entities and research institutions can access and contribute to high-quality, context-specific research that addresses critical gaps in knowledge, particularly regarding the health impacts of climate change and the effectiveness of adaptation strategies. These partners can also use CAPCHA as a platform to disseminate research findings, access new datasets, and engage with policymakers to ensure that their work has a real-world impact. CAPCHA will also provide opportunities for joint research initiatives that align with the needs of African countries.

Partners

Organizations, regional bodies, governments, and funders willing to contribute their resources and expertise are freely invited to partner with the CAPCHA Platform to strengthen its impact.

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